# 4 | South Asia's Nuclear Past

In chapter 3 we offer two competing views of nuclear weapons proliferation. Ganguly argues that nuclear weapons, far from destabilizing South Asia, actually constrained the prospect of major war in the region. He argues that the logic of nuclear deterrence, which had helped avoid major war among the great powers during the Cold War and had thereby contributed to the "long peace" in Europe, also holds in the South Asian context.[1] The sheer destructive properties of nuclear weapons ensures that decision makers act with a degree of caution and circumspection in the midst of international crises.

Kapur offers an approach to nuclear weapons proliferation that he calls strategic pessimism. Leading pessimistic arguments emphasize the danger of organizational pathologies, arguing that these problems will undermine states' ability to formulate rational security policies and to safely manage nuclear weapons. Strategic pessimism maintains that territorial preferences and conventional capabilities can create strong politico-military incentives for newly nuclear powers to behave aggressively. Thus nuclear proliferation can be dangerous and destabilizing based on states' rational calculation of their interests, quite apart from organizational shortcomings.

In this chapter, we discuss nuclear weapons' impact on Indo-Pakistani security relations from our competing theoretical viewpoints. We examine the period from the late 1980s, when India and Pakistan were beginning to acquire a de facto nuclear capability, through the Indo-Pakistani crisis of 2001–2002, when both countries were acknowledged nuclear powers. We seek to determine what, if any, impact nuclear weapons had on the outbreak, conduct, and resolution of regional crises during this period.